My Most Embarrassing Case Scenario

By Ellen DeGeneres

ACTOR 1: There are all sorts of books offering advice on how to deal with life-threatening situations, but where's the advice on dealing with embarrassing ones?

ACTOR 2: Things like landing a burning plane, wrestling a crocodile, or jumping from a moving train happen maybe five, six time in your life.

ACTOR 1: But embarrassing things happen hundreds of times each day. Here are a few things [we've] learned about how to survive life's embarrassing moments

INTRODUCTION

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ACTOR 2: SITUATION: FORGETTING SOMEONE'S NAME

ACTOR 1: You're at a party. Don't ask me how you were invited.

ACTOR 2: Either your host is very forgiving or he has a very short memory. Or else he realizes that it was partially his fault.

ACTOR 1: Why else would he be bragging about his new fireproof mattress if he didn't expect you to try it out?

ACTOR 2: And yes, in hindsight it is pretty obvious that just because the mattress is fireproof doesn't mean that the sheets and irreplaceable antique quilt are fireproof as well.

ACTOR 1: Anyway, that's all water under the bridge . . .

ACTOR 2: The same water, in fact, that you threw the burning quilt into to put it out.

ACTOR 1: Anyhoo, you're at the party, you notice an old friend walking toward you, and you start to panic.

ACTOR 2: You've forgotten your friends name! What do you do? What do you do?

ACTOR 1: SOLUTION

ACTOR 2: There are a few possible solutions to the "forgetting the name" problem. And I'm not talking about ridiculous ones like pretending to faint, then claiming you don't speak English.

ACTOR 1: That's not only silly, but it has been proven not to work after the incident when you set fire to your host's bedroom.

ACTOR 2: One solution is to have the same nickname for everyone. That way you only have to remember one name.

ACTOR 1: "Scooter!"

ACTOR 2: "Itchy!"

ACTOR 1: A second solution is to say "hi" to your old friend, then immediately grab hold of a third person and say all innocentlike . . .

ACTOR 2: "You two know each other, right?"

ACTOR 1: You wait for them to introduce themselves, and then sit back and relax.

ACTOR 2: The problem with this option is if the thir person just answers . . .

ACTOR 1: "No, I don't know this person,"

ACTOR 2: Now you find yourself in the doubly awkward position of having to introduce two people whose names you've forgotten.

ACTOR 1: I mean, you can always just say, "Scooter, this is Itchy. Itchy, Scooter."

ACTOR 2: But chances are that isn't going to work.

ACTOR 1: THE BEST SOLUTION

ACTOR 2: Say to her, "I'm sorry, remind me again how you pronounce your name?"

ACTOR 1: "Kathy"

ACTOR 2: That's right, the emphasis is on the first syllable, Ka-thy. I always think it's on the second, Ka-thy. I'm glad you corrected me, my old friend."

ACTOR 1: PROBLEM SOLVED!

ACTOR 2: SITUATION 2: LOSING YOURSELF IN THE MIDDLE OF A CONVERSATION

ACTOR 1: When our minds are deprived of stimulation, they dent to wander. The mind craves interesting conversation.

ACTOR 2: Which brings us back to the party and Ka-thy.

ACTOR 1: Kathy, it turns out, is a bore

ACTOR 2: Which I'm guessing is why you forgot her name in the first place.

ACTOR 1: She's been talkin gat you for a long time about this and that and you've just drifted off.

ACTOR 2: (sings) " . . . Fat Kids, skinny kids, even kids with chicken pox love hot dogs . . ."

ACTOR 1: You're kind of aware of her mouth moving, but you have no idea what she's saying. Then you hear the words . . .

ACTOR 2: "Inhaling Mold Spores"

ACTOR 1: And, like that, you're back. You have no idea what the subject of the conversation is, and Kathy has just stopped talking.

ACTOR 2: She's staring at you

ACTOR 1: (or slightly to the right of you because of her lazy eye)

ACTOR 2: expecting you to say something. What do you do? What do you do?

ACTOR 1: SOLUTION:

ACTOR 2: The only proven way to get yourself out of this embarrassing situation is to say something about Gloria Estefan.

ACTOR 1: I'm telling you, as long as you commit to it, she can fit into any conversation.

ACTOR 2: You don't believe [us]? Here's proof.

ACTOR 1: Kath is still staring at you waiting for a response . . . . . Finally you say

ACTOR 2: "That sounds a lot like Gloria Estefan"

ACTOR 1: Kathy looks at you funny and says,

ACTOR 2: "What that got to do with copper plumbing?"

ACTOR 1: To which you respond

ACTOR 2: "Well, Gloria Estefan is the copper plumbing of the music industry. She's beautiful, reliable and indestructible. Look how she came back after that bus accident! Are you going to debate me on this?!"

ACTOR 1: And, presto, you're back in the conversation and nobody's the wiser.

ACTOR 2: SITUATION: ACCIDENTLY REVEALING INTIMATE THOUGHTS TO A STRANGER

ACTOR 1: Revealing intimate thoughts to a stranger isn't always embarrassing. In fact, sometimes it's downright therapeutic.

ACTOR 2: Many people pay strangers to listen to their darkest fantasies and most perverse secret thoughts.

ACTOR 1: But, like most situations in life, when there is no money changing hands, the changes of being embarrassed multiply significantly.

ACTOR 2: So you're sill at the party, standing next to Kathy and you feel the need to reveal something deep and significant. So you say . . .

ACTOR 1: "My underwear keeps going up my crack."

ACTOR 2: "Excuse me?"

ACTOR 1: You turn and see not Kathy but a total stranger. Kathy has ditched you. The stranger looks at you and says loudly . . .

ACTOR 2: *(old lady voice)* "Did you just say your underwear keeps going into your crack?

ACTOR 1: People start to look at you. What do you do? What do you do?

ACTOR 2: SOLUTION

ACTOR 1: Deny, deny, deny! Calmly look at her and shriek "No, of course not. Are you kidding? What?! No!" or . . . .

ACTOR 2: Attack, attack, attack. Look at her and say, "Listen, I've had just about enough with the questions. Who are you, anyway? I don't know you. I don't owe you any explanation. You are way too curious for me, old lady. Why don't you go stand next to someone else and eavesdrop on them, you weirdo?!"

ACTOR 1: And that's usually when Kathy comes back and says . . .

ACTOR 2: "Oh, great, I see you've met our host's grandmother."

ACTOR 1: [And the last embarrassing] SITUATION: HUG, KISS, OR SHAKE HANDS

ACTOR 2: Believe it or not, it is as potentially awkward to greet someone whose name you remember as it is to greet Kathy.

ACTOR 1: That's because you never know what physical action to take upon greeting each other.

ACTOR 2: Do you shake their hand?

ACTOR 1: Do you hug them?

ACTOR 2: Do you kiss them?

ACTOR 1: Or, trickiest yet, do you to the complicated hug-kiss combo? *(demonstrate)* What do you do? What do you do?

ACTOR 2: SOLUTION

ACTOR 1: The answer to this dilemma is as simple as it is uncomplicated.

ACTOR 2: Let you friend make the first move and respond accordingly.

ACTOR 1: What's important for this strategy to work is to adopt the right stance so that you're ready for whatever physical greeting is about to be laid on you.

ACTOR 2: I recommend legs should-width apart, should leg-width apart, and arms outstretched but with a little bend in the elbow so that you don't look like you're being crucified.

ACTOR 1: If you friend, undertaking the same strategy, approaches you with the same stance, that's okay too.

ACTOR 2: I've had long conversations with people where both of us stood a foot away from each other, our arms outstretched, talking for hours.

TOGETHER: [And that's] how to survive life's embarrassing moments!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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